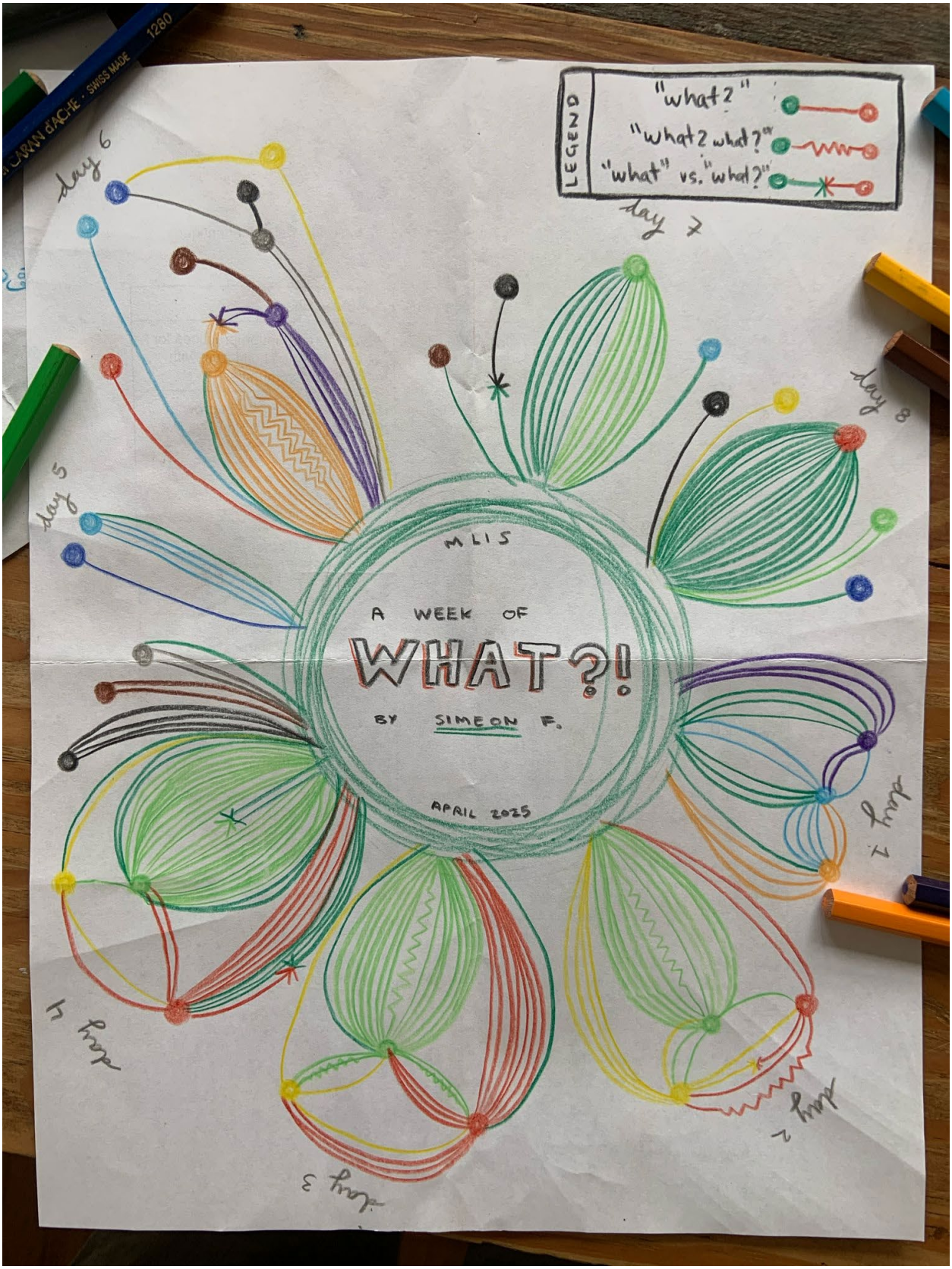

LEGEND
"what?"
"what? what?"
"what" vs. "what?"
day 1
day 2
day 3
day 4
day 5
day 6
day 7
day 8
MLIS
A WEEK OF
WHAT?!
BY SIMEON F.
APRIL 2025

A WEEK OF WHAT?!

What is our ultimate purpose in life.
—of uncertain provenance

W hat went down and other reĨ ections

Valentine's Day 2025 dawned crisp and clear, and we groggily piled into the car with our skis before any of us had fully woken up, any mumbled comment or direction received a grumbled–WHAT?!

I began collecting data on the Friday that opened my Reading Week, and we were skiing Million Dollar Couloir, an hour north of Pemberton. Hannah, Alec, and I were meeting up with their friend Diego in Squamish. The Vancouver trio had a long prehistory—last April we'd spontaneously ended up in the Bella Coola Valley for a week and had dubbed ourselves the *Mumbling Members of the Soft-Spoken Society* as we seldom spoke clearly and even more rarely understood each other. Backcountry skiing also doesn't help—each of us bundled in buffs and toques and helmets and the wind whispering all around louder than we'd wish.

I began surreptitiously noting on my hand each time someone followed up with, "what?" This included a couple of synonyms such as, "pardon me" or "hunh?" Of course there are a number of questionable aspects to my study. Acknowledging I often mishear does not inspire confidence in my reliability in collecting accurate data. Furthermore, I'm not around to hear everything that passes between others, so my dataset is skewed to interactions that I'm a part of. Finally, my own role as researcher, question developer, and data collector has meant, first, I thought about how often I said, "what?" and had some sense that it was maladaptive, and second, that it was front of mind for a week, allowing me to quickly adjust my behaviour, whether moving closer, or simply refusing to say, "what?" (notice I don't have a single "what?" day two). Hence, you'll notice that according to the UBC Office of Research Ethics, "tell me again how you pulled your head out of that hole," does not count as a synonym of "what?"

By lunch day one, however, my new friend Diego began his own research. "May I ask what you're collecting on your hand?" At first, I only heard the fourth word, so Diego → Simeon got another tick. But I knew my game was up—against all academic principles of scientific objectivity I was forced to tell my research subjects what I was up to. Surprisingly, my dataset didn't get too skewed (I believe there was only a single prank "what?"). I did adjust my procedure at this point to tell snooping participants that I consented to tell them what I was counting but only at the end of the evening, assuring them that I was not breaching their privacy in any way.

Lunch day one also marked the point where my data surpassed my logging tally technology infrastructure—I pulled out my phone. I was also struggling at this point on several other fronts. There was more than minimal risk with the sub-zero temperatures causing finger frost bite. My preliminary classification system was crumbling in real time in the messy real world. Hannah skiing

over a log which needed some air at the end to safely cross a creek elicited a—what?! What?! I hadn't learnt how to deal with this in school! What could be done?

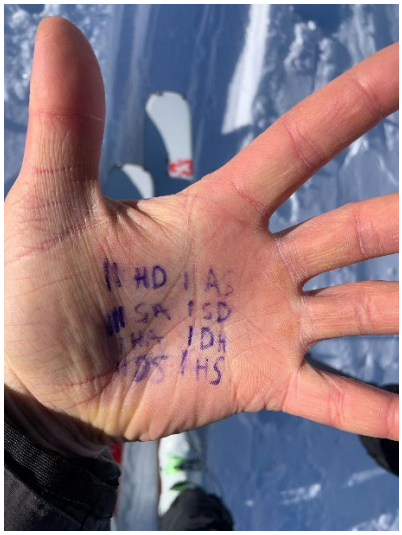
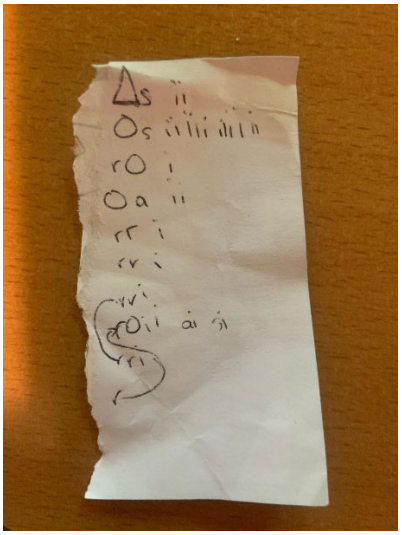
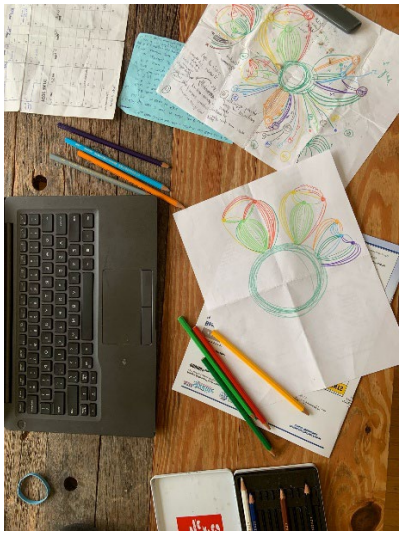
What to do when Hannah asked, "what?" twice in a row? What about Alec and Diego both saying it at once to each other? (asterisk it, then zigzags!) What if Diego said it just for another log? (discard it!) What if someone clearly misheard since they were repeating back what they had just (supposedly) heard erroneously, without specifically asking a question? What ways do I log two people saying, "what?" at once to me? What could be done with the what Hannah directed towards me for Diego? (code it as H→D) What about the "what?" question the sanity of an idea, rather than the comprehensibility of the symbols used to convey an idea? (it's all recorder interpretation) What if the incomprehension is about a whole conversation between multiple people? (code them as two separate instances)

The line began to blur as forgetfulness, shock, meaning, and fact-checking all reared their heads. Big data was taking over all aspects of my life. I ducked out of conversations at parties, scrambling for any working pen. My forearms a mess of track marks resembling the hypertrophied veins of a person with substance use disorder. My mind loosing sense of the proliferating ®s for each "random" whose name I didn't know, arrows criss-crossing between each. What might in fact subdue the lead investigator and expert in methods of research evaluation in information organizations—and no one would quite know *what was what*.

What the heck is this?

The large green circle represents me. Other folks reoccurred during my week, and I did consider collapsing days 2-4 as a singular "flowering" since the three friends I was on a hut trip were consistent, but then I saw my sister again at the end of the week, and so it was going to get complicated. Thus each day is kept separate. Perhaps on a digital platform it would be possible to have different visualizations of the data, and for example be able to click on a red node to center them and view their interactions across the week.

The lines out of a circle with the same colour signify that individual saying, "what?" to the individual represented by a different colour (e.g. yellow circle with a yellow line extending to a green circle). The zigzag represents saying, "what? what?" The two lines meeting halfway represent two people both saying, "what?" to each other at the same time. Spacing represents each 24-hour period, which I have labeled by day of the study. I tended to have a unique colour for different individuals, particularly in different settings. I also tried to symbolize relationships with related colours, thus partners tend to be light blue and dark blue, and siblings (my sister and I) are light green and dark green. In the end I only had eleven colours, so I sometimes had to repeat colours at random. My hope is that my visualization highlights some of the relationships between people in my life, and that patterns of interaction might emerge.

While I anonymized the data, some relationships certainly popped out for me. My sister (light green, days 2-4) and I chat a lot, but she is known to project easily and not hear as well, so she has an overwhelming number of clarifications directed at me. I will say, however, that she tends to say, “pardon me?” rather than “what?”—perhaps an adaption to often mishearing others. I would hypothesize that Naiomi (red, days 2-4) has a similar hearing style to my sister, based on how often I heard her say, “what?” and perhaps a similar relationship with her sister, Anna (yellow, days 2-4), if only I was able to better gather data. My roommate Jose (orange, day 5) is from Chile and has a hard time understanding my quiet voice, but we like chatting, so she had a ridiculous amount of “what?”s, often repeating the question. I went on a coffee date with my friend Chris (light green, day 6), and we are very similar, pretty much matching each other, “what?” for “what?”—I may induct him into the Soft-Spoken Society as a Mumbling Member.

Simeon Faehndrich, *April 7, 2025*